

Heart Valve Problems and Causes

Quick Facts

- A heart murmur is often the first sign of a valve problem.
- Heart valve problems can be present at birth, develop over time or be related to other health conditions.

Any heart problem can seem overwhelming, but many valve conditions can be treated.

Many heart valve problems are first found when a healthcare professional hears a [murmur](#). A murmur is a sound caused by blood moving through the heart that can be heard with a stethoscope. It may sound like a “whooshing” noise as blood flows from one chamber to the next.

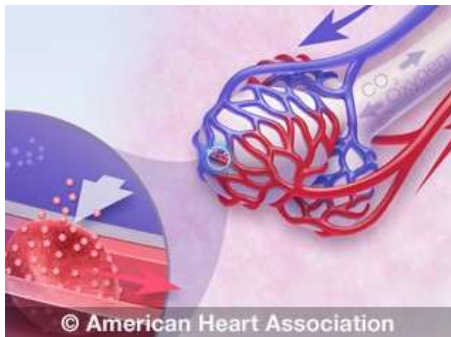
In some cases, abnormal valve movement can also create a brief clicking sound. These sound different than murmurs.

Some murmurs are harmless. Others may be a sign of a valve problem. If a murmur is detected, here are some possible causes.

Murmurs may indicate valve problems including:

- [Stenosis](#): A narrowing or stiffening of the valve that limits how much blood can flow through it
- [Regurgitation](#): The valve does not close completely, allowing blood to leak backward into the chamber
- [Atresia](#): The valve is completely closed

[View our heart valve animations library.](#)



Causes of valve problems

Heart valve problems can happen for different reasons. Some are present at [birth](#). Others develop over time or are linked to another health condition.

Congenital defects (abnormalities present at birth):

- [Aortic valve stenosis](#)
- [Ebstein's anomaly](#)
- [Pulmonary valve stenosis](#)
- Bicuspid aortic valve

Aging and age-related valve disease include:

- Degenerative valve disease: Over time, heart valves can slowly wear down or change. For example, [mitral valve prolapse](#) affects about 2% to 3% of people and can lead to [mitral valve regurgitation](#), which may need treatment.
- Calcification due to aging: As people age, fats, inflammation, fibrosis and calcium can build up on the valves. This can make the valves thicker and stiffer. It most often affects the aortic valve and can lead to aortic stenosis.
- Radiation therapy to the chest: Studies have shown that people who had radiation therapy to the chest, especially during childhood, have a higher chance of developing valve disease later in life.

Some related illnesses and conditions that can cause valve problems include:

- [Infective endocarditis](#)
- Injury
- [Rheumatic fever](#)

These conditions can cause one or more heart valves to leak blood backward or not open fully. This can make the heart work harder and reduce how well it pumps blood.

Some valve problems can be serious. But many can be treated, especially when found early.

Heart Valve Disease Resources

- [What is Heart Valve Disease? \(PDF\)](#)
- [HVD Discussion Guide \(PDF\)](#)
- [Understanding Heart Valve Disease \(PDF\)](#)
- [After HVD Diagnosis Discussion Guide \(PDF\)](#)
- [Symptom Tracker \(PDF\)](#)



Valve Regurgitation: When a Heart Valve Leaks



Video: Heart Murmurs and Valve Problems



Heart Valve Disease



Heart Valves and Circulation

Heart Valve Problems and Causes



- Heart Valve Stenosis
 - Aortic Stenosis
 - Aortic Stenosis Overview
 - Mitral Valve Stenosis
 - Tricuspid Valve Stenosis
 - Pulmonary Valve Stenosis
- Mitral Valve Prolapse
- Heart Valve Regurgitation
 - Aortic Valve Regurgitation
 - Mitral Valve Regurgitation
 - Tricuspid Valve Regurgitation
 - Pulmonary Valve Regurgitation
- Left Ventricular Hypertrophy

Risks and Diagnosis



Getting an Accurate Diagnosis



Treatment Options



Recovery and Healthy Living Goals



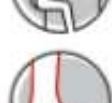
Personal Stories



Heart Valve Disease Resources



Related Articles

	Pain, tightness or pressure in the chest	☐ Never	☐ Occasionally	☐ Often	☐ Always
.....					
	Lightheadedness or dizziness	☐ Never	☐ Occasionally	☐ Often	☐ Always
.....					
	Shortness of breath	☐ Never	☐ Occasionally	☐ Often	☐ Always
.....					
	Rapid fluttering heartbeat	☐ Never	☐ Occasionally	☐ Often	☐ Always
.....					
	Fainting	☐ Never	☐ Occasionally	☐ Often	☐ Always
.....					
	Difficulty sleeping or sitting up	☐ Never	☐ Occasionally	☐ Often	☐ Always
.....					
	Swollen ankles or feet	☐ Never	☐ Occasionally	☐ Often	☐ Always
.....					
	Difficulty walking short distances	☐ Never	☐ Occasionally	☐ Often	☐ Always
.....					

Symptoms of Heart Valve Disease